

Battle of Britain
An RAF fighter pilot sits in the cockpit of his Supermarine Spitfire after returning from combat over Britain in July 1940 *(above)*. Each pilot was issued with an Enfield Mk1.38 revolver in the event of being downed in enemy territory *(right)*.

In the summer of 1940, Britain's RAF Fighter Command faced a sustained air offensive by bomber and fighter aircraft of the German Luftwaffe. Known as the Battle of Britain, this was the first battle fought exclusively in the air. It was a conflict for which the RAF had made some preparation, chiefly in the form of radar masts placed around the coast, but it remained a knife-edge contest. The defence of Britain depended upon a remarkably small number of pilots (around 1,500 at full strength) who fought to the limit of their endurance.

Before the war, the RAF attracted a stream of volunteers, some of whom were then assigned to the aircraft flown by Fighter Command. Young men were excited by the prospect of flying Britain's fast new monoplane fighters, the Supermarine Spitfire and the Hawker Hurricane. They were also aware that, as fighter pilots, they would be objects of male envy and female desire. One pilot described RAF fighter service as just "beer, women and Spitfires". In the class-bound British society of the 1930s, Fighter Command came to be regarded by some officers as an elite flying club. Some of them were recruited through socially exclusive organizations such as the Auxiliary Air Force and the Oxford University Air Squadron, bringing with them the public school ethos of the "stiff upper lip" and a bantering, self-deprecatory tone. But aspiring fliers from outside the privileged class also gained entry to Fighter Command, through the Volunteer Reserve. Most of these volunteers flew as sergeant pilots, rather than officers.

OVERSEAS PILOTS

About 20 per cent of Fighter Command's pilots in the Battle of Britain were non-British. One in ten were provided by Commonwealth countries, with New Zealanders the most numerous single group. Commonwealth pilots were often better shots than the British, whose training put less emphasis on marksmanship. Other Fighter Command pilots were refugees from Occupied Europe, including Poles, Czechs, French, and Belgians. The Poles comprised the largest European contingent, and the most motivated; beaten by the Luftwaffe during the invasion of Poland in September 1939, they were hot for revenge. Whatever their origins, all fighter pilots were young – in principle no one over the age of 26 was allowed to lead a squadron, although the two greatest leaders in the Battle of Britain were exceptions – "Sailor" Malan and Douglas Bader were both aged 30.

BATTLE COMMENCES

In the spring of 1940, Fighter Command took on the Luftwaffe in the battle for France and during the evacuation of the British army from Dunkirk. These early encounters showed that the Germans were better at air fighting than the RAF, with more experienced pilots and superior tactics. After clashes over the Channel through July, the German aerial onslaught on southern England began in earnest in the second week of August, with fleets of bombers, escorted by Messerschmitt fighters, attacking in daylight whenever the weather permitted. The aim of the Luftwaffe campaign was to establish air supremacy, thus opening the way for a seaborne invasion of Britain. Fighter Command chief Hugh Dowding intended to keep his fighter pilots and aircraft in existence as a viable defensive force, and husbanded resources to that end. The RAF squadrons based at airfields in southern England found themselves in the front line of the fighting, as the vast majority of Luftwaffe raids were launched across the Channel from bases in northern France.



ENFIELD MK1 .38 REVOLVER AND AMMUNITION